



FISHERMAN Axel Bjorklund, right, and Bradlee Titus pull a crab pot from the Pacific Ocean late last month near Bodega Bay, Calif. BRIAN VANDER BRUG Los Angeles Times

It was a calm January morning, the waters off Bodega Bay unusually smooth, but crab fisherman Dick Ogg couldn't shake a grim feeling that the day wouldn't go his way.

The Dungeness crab season had opened just a few weeks earlier — two months behind schedule — and was off to a slow start. "We're working very hard to basically get nothing," said Ogg.

The anemic hauls so early in the season mark the latest setback for California's commercial Dungeness crab fishery, a roughly \$45-million-a-year industry that delivers one of the state's most iconic culinary delights.

The industry's future has been complicated by another celebrated sea creature: Each year, a number of humpback whales migrating through California's waters to and from tropical breeding

Regulations an existential issue for crab fishers

With shorter season and limits on gear, they wonder if industry can survive state protections for whales

By Hannah Wiley | REPORTING FROM BODEGA BAY, CALIF.

grounds get entangled in commercial crab fishing gear, encounters that often end in mutilation or death. State regulators are intent on lowering the chances of whales coming into contact with the gear.

There's reason to be concerned.

Since 1970, when the federal government listed humpback whales as "endangered" after they were hunted to near extinction, the population has made a fragile comeback. Whales along the West Coast have recovered at an estimated annual rate of 8.2% since the 1980s, according to the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration, with more than 4,500 humpback whales now feeding off California's coast.

The state Department of Fish and Wildlife has imposed sharp restrictions on the crab industry [See *Dungeness*, A8]

WILDFIRE RECOVERY CHIEF TO FORGO HIS PAY

Decision comes after criticism over Steve Soboroff's \$500,000 salary, to be funded by charitable groups.

By DAVID ZAHNISER, DAKOTA SMITH AND JULIA WICK

Faced with fierce criticism over her chief wildfire recovery officer's planned salary of \$500,000 for 90 days of work, Los Angeles Mayor Karen Bass reversed course Saturday evening and said Steve Soboroff would receive no compensation.

Soboroff's original salary, which would have been funded entirely by charitable organizations, was first reported by The Times early Saturday. Soboroff had defended the arrangement, saying his expertise made him worth the price.

After her reversal, Bass said in a statement: "Steve is always there for L.A. I spoke to him today and asked him to modify his agreement and work for free. He said yes. We agree that we don't need anything distracting from the recovery work we're doing." [See *Soboroff*, A10]

Who's leading recovery effort?

In Pacific Palisades, L.A. mayor's appointees, nonprofits and more complicate the answer. **A10**

Trump's remaking of '9th Circus'

Legal challenges to his agenda sidestep court, where his appointees occupy 10 of 29 seats.

By SONJA SHARP

More than 18,000 Californians have been born since President Trump signed his executive order to end birthright citizenship last month — among them, about 9,000 children of immigrants.

Yet, when the American Civil Liberties Union sued to stop the Jan. 20 order, it didn't file in San Francisco, where its lawyers are based and where half of all children have an immigrant parent.

Instead, the lawsuit was filed in Concord, N.H., where under 5% of residents are foreign-born.

A similar suit brought by California officials in coalition with 17 other states likewise sidestepped the federal court in San Francisco, preferring instead to file in Boston.

Experts say the filings reflect a seismic shift in the U.S. appellate courts. The 9th Circuit, once the left flank of the federal appellate system and the president's self-proclaimed adversary, is no longer a bastion of legal resistance.

[See *Court*, A7]



MATT ROTA For The Times

A PLANNED VEGAS ARENA IS AN EMPTY PIT

Ex-NBA player repeatedly promised to build a massive resort on the Strip. Then it all fell apart.

By Nathan Fenno | REPORTING FROM LAS VEGAS

Even in a city accustomed to outlandish projects and long-shot bets, Jackie Lee Robinson's \$5-billion vision for Las Vegas stood out.

The NBA champion proposed building an arena — sheathed in giant LED screens and crowned with a retractable roof — to anchor an enormous development without a casino in a less-visited part of the Strip.

At a celebratory news conference in October 2022, a promotional video promised to transform 27 acres of barren land into a world-class destination. Robinson

called it the All Net Resort and Arena, using basketball slang for a shot so perfect the ball passes through the net without touching the rim.

A member of the powerful Clark County Commission seated next to Robinson praised "the faith, the belief, the moxie to dream outside the box," while Nevada's then-lieutenant governor gushed that the privately financed project "truly is incredible." Small-time investors had faith in Robinson, too, and had poured millions into the undertaking.

[See *Arena*, A6]

Hamas lets world know it's survived

The militant group continues freeing hostages but has held its grip on Gaza despite Israel's efforts.

By LAURA KING

TEL AVIV — This past weekend, as Hamas paraded a trio of emaciated Israeli hostages who were about to be freed after more than a year of captivity in the Gaza Strip, the militant group seized the chance to direct a personal gibe at Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu.

With news cameras in southern Gaza lingering on a knot of masked fighters, a Hebrew-language banner

was clearly visible behind them, superimposed with the prime minister's face.

"Total victory," it read — mocking the refrain often invoked by the Israeli leader during nearly 16 months of brutal warfare in the coastal enclave, now paused by a truce.

Embarking on a round of highly charged new talks over the next phase of the cease-fire, both Hamas and Israel are trying to paint themselves as victors, even as Gaza lies in ruins.

Although Hamas sustained heavy blows in a withering campaign of Israeli bombardment coupled with a months-long ground offensive, some observers believe the group is scoring significant propaganda points — because it can point to its survival.

[See *Hamas*, A4]

Super Bowl LIX

For coverage of Sunday's NFL matchup between the Chiefs and the Eagles, visit latimes.com/sports.

CNN's plan for post-cable world

Network pivots to new products aimed at digital users in its online push. **BUSINESS, A12**

Weather

Partly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 64/46. **B6**

An artist's eye for beauty amid loss

A painter who captured Altadena for 40 years plans a postfire exhibition. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

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